as the trade centre of Tagara, which suggests that the Pompeii Lakshmi was exported from India by way of one of the half-dozen or so major entrepots dotted along the Gujarat or Malabar coasts that came into their own in the first century BCE. Alternatively, she could have taken ship from Tamralipti, identified as the modern town of Tamluk, which is sited some 25 miles (40 kilometres) east of Kolkata beside what was formerly one of the many channels of the Ganges. This was the port from which Ashoka's daughter Sanghamitta set sail for Lanka with her father's gift of a cutting from the Bodhi tree of Bodhgaya in about the year 250 BCE.



One of the earliest depictions of the goddess Shri standing or seated on a lotus while being washed by elephants, in the form that came to be known within Hinduism as Gajalakshmi, or 'Lakshmi and elephants' (from a roundel on the Barhut stupa railing, c. 160 BCE).